

Chapter 188 - Part 1

Extra 10-1

"Did she really kneel and kowtow up three thousand steps?" A somewhat weathered male voice sounded outside the hospital room.

A female voice that had cried until hoarse, carrying a nasal tone, answered: "Mm."

The man paused, waiting a few seconds: "Disgraceful."

"What do you mean by that?" The woman looked up, her face somewhat pale. She'd cried for too long, her eyes were red. "She's already lying in a hospital bed, can't you say something nice?"

"What nice things?" The man frowned and snorted coldly: "I said it long ago, her dating was wrong from the start."

"Uncle." Zhao Ying's cold voice sounded from the side, "Please say less."

Her words were still respectful, but also carried a bit of impatience.

Zhao's father had always doted on his niece Zhao Ying, precisely because Zhao Ying was much better at handling things than Zhao Xuning. She was always attentive with greetings and concerns, making everyone comfortable.

Not like Zhao Xuning, who aside from being smart was worthless in everything else.

So at this time, Zhao Ying's words were still effective.

Zhao's father frowned, wanting to say something, but in the end said nothing.

Zhao Ying stood to the side comforting Zhao's mother, "Auntie, you don't need to worry. Ning Ning is a doctor, she definitely knows what she's doing. When has she ever done anything to harm herself since childhood?"

Zhao's mother felt stifled, saying with a sob: "But she's so stubborn."

Zhao Ying: "..."

Zhao Ying was also afraid that the more she consoled, the more upset Zhao's mother would become, so she simply shut her mouth.

The hospital corridor was quiet. The best thing about VIP wards was this.

Inside the room, Zhao Xuning also lay quietly in bed, her forehead wrapped in thick layers of gauze, lying there without energy, eyes closed and motionless.

Still trapped in unconsciousness.

Zhao Ying did know some things about Zhao Xuning and Shen Hui.

Zhao Xuning's personality was too awkward; she didn't have many friends. Sometimes when she drank too much and felt stifled, she'd call Zhao Ying, so later Zhao Ying would occasionally tease Zhao Xuning about Shen Hui.

Zhao Ying thought Zhao Xuning would be able to let go.

Because since childhood, whatever Zhao Xuning wanted, she almost always got.

Otherwise, she would simply and decisively let go.

She'd never seen Zhao Xuning waver over anything.

If Zhao Ying and Zhao Ling went shopping together, they might have decision paralysis picking this and that, but Zhao Xuning wouldn't have this problem.

Zhao Xuning would definitely pick out what she wanted very efficiently, then go pay.

The word "hesitation" simply didn't appear in Zhao Xuning's life dictionary.

But she happened to meet Shen Hui.

Zhao Ying even calculated in her mind the probability of Zhao Xuning and Shen Hui getting back together, leaning more toward the two going their separate ways.

Because Zhao Xuning was too proud, too proud to bow her head.

And who was Shen Hui?

How could she possibly compromise for Zhao Xuning again and again?

But Zhao Ying never expected that one day, Zhao Xuning would kneel and kowtow up three thousand steps, not knowing whether it was to beg Shen Hui's forgiveness or to get back together with her.

When she saw her name trending on hot search and watched that video on the trending topic, Zhao Ying rubbed her eyes several times and had her assistant confirm it for her.

That really was Zhao Xuning.

It was that Zhao Xuning who was proud beyond measure.

When Zhao Ying rushed to the hospital, Zhao Xuning was still in the ward, and the doctor had given her fever-reducing injections.

But Zhao's parents still knew nothing about it. They blamed Zhao Xuning for disgracing the Zhao family, blamed Zhao Xuning for being useless—how could she throw away even her dignity for a woman?!

Listening to this, Zhao Ying felt terrible inside.

Although she didn't know why Zhao Xuning would do such a thing, Zhao Ying still protected Zhao Xuning.

Inside the ward, Zhao Xuning remained trapped in unconsciousness.

Calling it unconsciousness wasn't quite right—it was more like a gentle dream.

Heaven and earth became a huge, gentle cocoon, and she was wrapped inside it, which made her feel joyful.

Before long, she saw Shen Hui.

It was Shen Hui from their university days, appearing before her wearing a beautiful dress. Whenever she saw her, the corners of Shen Hui's eyes would lift, the arc of her mouth would curve upward. Back then, when Shen Hui smiled, her eyes sparkled brightly, looking as if she'd put the moon in her eyes.

Shen Hui always loved to call her: "Hey, Zhao Xuning."

When acting cute, she'd shake her arm and call: "Ning Ning wife, Ning Ning baby."

If she happened to bump or knock into something one day, she'd definitely call out aggrieved: "Wife~ it hurts."

Her voice milky and soft.

Clearly that wasn't her natural voice tone, but when those words came from her mouth, they were particularly pleasant to hear, making one feel particularly indulged.

Just thinking of past scenes made Zhao Xuning feel delighted.

That was happiness accumulated day by day.

If this was a dream, then Zhao Xuning wished to never wake from this long dream.

Zhao Xuning thought, her Ah Hui should be forever happy.

Forever maintaining that girlish state.

But she had destroyed such a Shen Hui.

So later, whenever Shen Hui saw her, she always had a cold face, her eyes always turning red.

Those insurmountable obstacles between them were like a walled city, trapping people in two separate worlds.

But would Shen Hui really be happy leaving her?

Would the people she met really be better than her?

Zhao Xuning's state of mind changed, and along with it, the dreamscape changed.

Slanting wind and cold rain, clouds of frost and fog and snow.

All quite unpleasant.

Later, in a patch of white mist, Shen Hui stood at the edge of a cliff, smiling as she waved at her, as if saying goodbye.

Then her body tilted backward and fell. Zhao Xuning's eyes widened as she ran forward, but caught nothing—only emptiness.

Zhao Xuning suddenly opened her eyes.

What met her gaze was blinding white, surrounded by the familiar smell of disinfectant. The pain from her forehead helped her distinguish dream from reality.

Even so, her back was covered in cold sweat.

Chapter 188 - Part 2

Extra 10-2

Zhao Xuning turned her head and saw Zhao Ying dozing off with her chin propped up, sitting in front of the hospital bed.

Perhaps her movement startled Zhao Ying, who quickly woke up and made direct eye contact with her.

"You're awake." Zhao Ying stood up, pressing the call button by the bedside, then asked with concern: "How are you? Does your head still hurt?"

Zhao Xuning struggled to shake her head slowly, "How long did I sleep?"

"A day and a half." Zhao Ying said.

Zhao Xuning asked again: "Where's Shen Hui?"

Zhao Ying: "..."

"Is she alright?" Zhao Xuning asked again.

Zhao Ying shook her head: "She should be fine."

Shen Hui had also knelt for over a thousand steps with her. Zhao Xuning stared blankly at the door, saying nothing more.

She still hadn't fully emerged from the dream.

This state continued until evening.

During this time, Liang Shi came, Xu Qingzhu came, Zhao Ling came, and her parents came.

Everyone who saw her had serious expressions, all tight-lipped, as if her act of kneeling and kowtowing for three thousand steps hadn't happened.

Actually, Zhao Xuning could understand.

Everyone must be in shock.

If many years ago someone had told Zhao Xuning that one day she would kneel and kowtow up three thousand steps to win back a woman, Zhao Xuning would definitely have rolled her eyes, thinking they were sick.

But she never expected she would do it.

Even she herself couldn't think of it.

She couldn't even say why she had to do it.

In that instant, as long as Shen Hui asked, she would do it.

It had probably reached a kind of crazy degree.

That was the first time she realized—oh, so she loved Shen Hui to the point of madness.

Crazy.

Zhao Xuning cursed herself like this in her heart.

Zhao Xuning lay in the hospital room for an entire day, seemingly calm, but her heart was not calm.

She kept unconsciously looking outside the ward, again and again.

But never waiting for the person she wanted to wait for.

Until the second day, when Shen Hui appeared outside her hospital room.

When Zhao Xuning saw Shen Hui, neither of them spoke.

One standing, one sitting.

For a long time, so long that Zhao Xuning felt she was about to suffocate, unable to adjust her rhythm, Shen Hui finally spoke her first words: "Are you better?"

Just a simple greeting, but Zhao Xuning felt her throat go dry. When answering, she wanted to smile but couldn't manage it.

In the end, she gave up.

Zhao Xuning answered: "More or less."

Shen Hui sat by her bedside, not knowing what to say either.

All in all, the atmosphere was somewhat awkward.

Then Shen Hui took an apple from the side and handed it to her, "Can you still do it?"

Zhao Xuning pressed her lips together and asked tentatively: "Do you want to eat?"

Shen Hui leaned back, casual and careless: "Want to watch."

Zhao Xuning picked up the fruit knife from the side. Her fingers were slender, and the back of her hand was mottled with bruises from too many IV drips, looking shocking.

She lowered her eyes and quietly began peeling the apple.

When Zhao Xuning first practiced her hand skills, to train her wrist strength and finger dexterity, she used apples for practice.

Back then, after they finished anatomy class, when Zhao Xuning had nothing to do, she would peel apples.

Shen Hui joked with her: "I'm about to become an apple spirit."

But that said, during that time Shen Hui's skin condition was particularly good.

But what Shen Hui liked most was watching her peel apple skins.

It was a blessing for those with obsessive-compulsive disorder.

She would maintain almost the same width, never breaking.

Mainly because Zhao Xuning looked particularly good when focusing on something.

Shen Hui especially loved looking at her profile.

Zhao Xuning quietly finished peeling an apple, then handed it to Shen Hui.

Shen Hui held it and took a bite—very crisp.

The ward fell silent again.

Zhao Xuning's fingers slid back and forth along the same line on the bedsheet.

Shen Hui slowly ate a few bites, then asked without warning: "Why won't you let me get engaged?"

Zhao Xuning pressed her lips together, not answering.

"Is it because you still love me, or possessiveness?" Shen Hui asked again.

Zhao Xuning still didn't speak, not knowing how to answer.

She didn't want Shen Hui to know about those things.

That person had abandoned his pregnant girlfriend to be with her. That person was cold and cruel.

Handing Shen Hui over to such a person, Zhao Xuning couldn't feel at ease.

"Zhao Xuning." Shen Hui stared straight at her, her voice turning cold: "Speak."

With a hint of coercion.

Zhao Xuning didn't dare look at her.

"So you still want things to be like before?" Shen Hui asked.

Zhao Xuning shook her head: "No."

Shen Hui: "Then what do you want?"

Only then did Zhao Xuning look at Shen Hui.

After a long moment of eye contact, Zhao Xuning opened her mouth with difficulty: "I want to be with you."

Zhao Xuning paused, tears suddenly welling up in her eyes, feeling a pain in her heart.

She said: "Even if you torture me, I'm willing."

Zhao Xuning closed her eyes, a tear falling.

"Shen Hui." Zhao Xuning said: "Let me keep you."

That year, Shen Hui had said, "Zhao Xuning, if one day I want to break up with you, you just say 'let me keep you,' and then I'll know—you can't bear to part with me, I'm the one you love most in the whole world, you can't live without me. That way, I'll stay by your side. Understand?"

When Shen Hui said this, she was smiling, sitting with Zhao Xuning at the highest point of a drop tower¹, holding her hand tightly.

Then she shouted into the wind: "In the whole world, I love Zhao Xuning the most."

But Zhao Xuning had never said those words.

Zhao Xuning sat on the hospital bed, feeling her throat so dry she could barely speak. Every word felt difficult, her heart aching and afraid.

Afraid Shen Hui would refuse, afraid Shen Hui would scold her, even more afraid Shen Hui would leave without looking back, negating everything from the past.

But after a long while, Shen Hui looked up at her and smiled: "Alright."

When she smiled and said those two words, Shen Hui thought: What a fool.

Jumping into Zhao Xuning's world again and again.

Yes.

A crazy person and a fool.

They matched quite well.

Footnotes:

¹ Drop tower (跳楼机) - An amusement park ride that lifts riders to a height and then drops them in free fall